

CAMELS



WELL-SUITED TO DESERT LIFE, camels can withstand extreme conditions. There are two main types: the one-humped dromedary, which lives in Africa and Arabia, and is usually domesticated; and the two-humped Asian Bactrian, some of which still roam wild in the Gobi Desert. Closely related to camels are four animals without humps – llamas, alpacas, guanacos, and vicunas. All six species, called camelids, belong to the artiodactyls, a group of herbivorous, even-toed mammals that also includes cattle.

Feet

Camels' feet have two toes joined by a web of skin; underneath is a soft, flexible pad that splays out when the camel walks. The camel's feet are very wide, and this, together with the pad, prevents the camel from sinking into soft sand and enables it to walk over rough terrain.



Web of skin

Foot of dromedary

Large, wide feet with soft pads allow camel to walk on sand.

Thick fur keeps camel warm during cold desert nights, and helps prevent overheating in the day.

Shaggy fur

Bactrian camel

Long legs help camel walk long distances.

Dromedary camel

Long, curved neck, allows camel to reach desert vegetation.

Features of a camel

Camels are the largest of the even-toed mammals, standing up to 2.4 m (8 ft) at the shoulder. They have long legs, and walk at an ambling pace. Camels have a split upper lip, which allows them to eat dry, spiky plants. Their lips and upright heads have given camels a reputation for arrogance. In reality this is nonsense. However, camels may spit at, or bite, humans if annoyed or frightened. During the mating season, male camels often fight, biting their rivals when competing for females.

Hump

Contrary to popular belief, the camel's hump is not filled with water, but is a fat store that provides the camel with energy when food is scarce. Because fat is stored in the hump, there is less fat under the rest of the skin enabling the camel to lose heat more easily in hot conditions.



Long eye lashes

Slit-like nostrils

Split upper lip

Head of dromedary camel

Eyes and nostrils

Camels have long eyelashes that protect their eyes from fierce sandstorms and enable them to see under difficult conditions. They can close their slit-like nostrils to reduce the amount of sand and dust blowing up the nose, and minimize moisture loss from the nasal cavity.

Ships of the desert

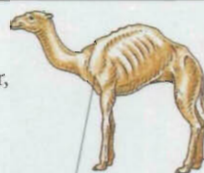
Camels are the only animals that can carry heavy loads long distances in extreme heat and with little water. Nomadic peoples survive in deserts by using camels as pack animals, as well as for meat, milk, and skins.



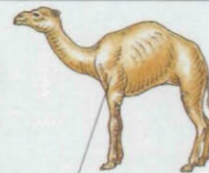
Salt-laden caravan, Taoudenni, Mali

Water loss

Camels can exist for long periods without water, but make up the loss quickly when water is available. Camels are also adapted to reduce water loss by producing dry faeces and small amounts of syrupy urine. In addition, their body temperature can rise to 40.5°C (104.9°F) during the day, reducing the need to keep cool by sweating, a process that also causes water loss.



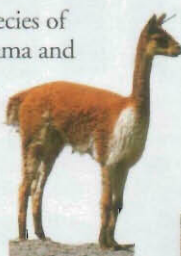
During long periods without drinking, a camel can lose 40 per cent of its body mass as water.



Within 10 minutes, camels can drink sufficient water to make up huge losses.

Types of camelid

Related to camels are two species of domesticated camelid, the llama and alpaca, and two wild species, the vicuna and guanaco; all live in or near the Andes mountains in South America. Small herds of guanaco feed on grass and shrubs in shrubland and savannah up to heights of 4,250 m (13,900 ft), from southern Peru to southern Argentina.



Vicuna

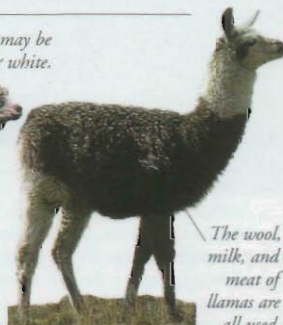
Vicunas, the smallest of the camelids, live in family groups at high altitudes.



Vicunas are a protected species.

Alpaca

The highland peoples of Peru and Bolivia breed alpacas for their long, soft wool.



Alpacas' wool may be black, brown, or white.

The wool, milk, and meat of llamas are all used.

Llama

Llamas are used as pack animals to carry loads of up to 100 kg (220 lb), at altitudes of 5,000 m (16,400 ft) over long distances.

DROMEDARY CAMEL

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Camelus dromedarius*

ORDER Artiodactyla

FAMILY Camelidae

DISTRIBUTION Domesticated in North Africa, Middle East, southwestern Asia; feral populations in Australia

HABITAT Desert

DIET Any type of desert vegetation, including thorny twigs and salty plants that other animals avoid

SIZE Head and body length 3 m (10 ft); shoulder height 2 m (6.5 ft); weight up to 600 kg (1,320 lb)

LIFESPAN Up to 50 years